

THREE MAJOR CIVILIZATIONS

The Aztec civilization was based in what is now central Mexico. The Maya occupied southern Mexico, Guatemala, Belize, Honduras, and El Salvador. The Inca empire stretched 4,000 km (2,486 miles) along the west coast of South America.



Ancient Americas

Three great civilizations of the Americas flourished in different parts of the continent: the Maya and Aztecs in central America (Mesoamerica) and the Inca in the south, centred in modern-day Peru. These cultures, although different in many ways, all left behind beautiful art and the remains of spectacular cities.



MACHU PICCHU
A remote outpost of the Inca empire, up to half of its 143 buildings may have been used for religious ceremonies.

DIVERSE CULTURES

As well as the Maya, Aztec, and Inca civilizations, a rich mosaic of other peoples and cultures flourished in the region.

- MAYA (c.2000 BCE–1697 CE)**
Excelled at astronomy, and devised a way of writing using pictures. There are still millions of Maya in Central America today.
- OLMEC (1200–400 BCE)**
One of the earliest civilizations of Mesoamerica, their culture was based mainly on farming and trade.
- ZAPOTEC (500 BCE–900 CE)**
Based in southern Mexico. Ruled over 1,000 settlements in the region from its main city, Monte Albán.
- TEOTIHUACAN (1–750 CE)**
Built Teotihuacan, the largest and most impressive city in the ancient Americas.
- NAZCA (100–800 CE)**
Best known for the massive pictures and shapes (geoglyphs) they etched on the ground in southern Peru.
- MOCHE (100–800 CE)**
Built huge, mysterious pyramids, from mud bricks, that still dominate the countryside in northern Peru.
- TOLTEC (750–1170)**
Expert Mesoamerican architects and craftsmen. Built giant pyramids and palaces in their capital, Tula.
- CHIMU (1000–1470)**
Occupying a large area in the west of South America, they were skilled goldsmiths and architects. Eventually conquered by the Incas.
- INCA (1150–1532)**
Became the most powerful people in the Andes mountain region when they conquered the city of Cuzco in 1438. They went on to take over many other states for their empire.
- AZTEC (1300s–1521)**
Originally a wandering tribe, they founded the city of Tenochtitlan in 1325, which became the centre of their mighty empire.

GREAT CITIES

Cities were built in a variety of places. The surrounding landscape and the building materials available had an effect on the look of the buildings. Cities were often dominated by huge temples and other religious buildings.



TIKAL
Major Maya city, inhabited from 600 BCE to around 900 CE.



CHICHEN ITZA
Maya city that was an important trading centre.



CUZCO
The religious and political capital of the Incas.



TEOTIHUACAN
City state that was destroyed mysteriously around 700 CE.



AZTEC SUN STONE
Describes the Aztecs' beliefs about time and religion.

WRITING

Many of the different Mesoamerican cultures used picture-writing to keep records and write about their history. The Inca and their neighbours did not use writing, but recorded information on a *quipu*, an arrangement of knotted strings.

MAYA WRITING
Made up of a system of symbols, called glyphs.

SKY	PERSON	MOUNTAIN	SUN	JAGUAR	FIRE
BONE	SPIRIT	BOOK	WATER	LORD	CLOUD
WOMAN	TO GRAB	QUETZAL	SNAKE	HOLY	TO SCATTER
YEAR	BLUE	SHIELD	FLINT	HOUSE	TWENTY